Consequences

by Aaron Fraire



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Please Note: This role is written as a male, but it may be played by a female. Adjustments are allowed for pronouns and spouse references, if desired.

The Interrogator is a CIA defense contractor working in Iraq. The Interrogator is a master manipulator who can be both friendly and sinister. He can turn on a dime and is always engaged in psychological warfare. However, he has also been in this job for too long and has seen too much. As a result, he is as fractured as many of the detainees he interviews.

INTERROGATOR. Hey, you're the new guy? OK. Well…

You've seen the rest of the base? Good. Well, this is the break room. No, no, not "the breaking" room. We don't do interrogations in here. This is just for us. This room has carpet.

This room is just for us. We come here to reset between interrogations. So, if you need to vomit or wash up, you'll do it there. If you need whiskey, or a cigarette, or pills to get right, they're there. There's porn there, there, and there. And if you're religious…sorry. God's not here. We tell God to wait outside.

Welcome to Iraq…hell's outhouse. Charming, right?

In April 2004, CBS News published proof that the United States Army and the CIA had committed torture and human rights violations against detainees in the Abu Ghraib prison in Iraq. While some defended these actions as interrogation tactics and wartime necessities, others argued that such measures were inhumane and thoroughly un-American. In his play, Aaron Fraire examines the cost of torture from an unusual vantage point – the interrogator. Ultimately suggesting that when we abandon our humanity, even in the name of duty, we must be prepared for Consequences by Aaron Fraire.

INTERROGATOR. Here's how it works. Every few days a truck full of assets arrives and we sort them into priority intelligence groups – PIGs. And every one of these PIGs comes with a folder like this one. Inside we have every piece of information available: addresses, aliases, contacts, bank accounts, blood type, shoe size. Sometimes they are large packets of information. Other times, it's just one sentence: Suspected of Anti-Coalition Activities. You just never know.

And here, on the front, it tells us what the objectives are and what level PIG we're dealing with.

See, level 1 PIGs are worthless guys – messengers, foot soldiers, etc. Level 2 PIGs are important, but not directly responsible parties – brokers, family members, coordinators, and the like. And Level 3 PIGs are the doers - bombmakers, spies, kidnappers, the nameless faceless terrorists that make this world

so uncomfortable. Every once in awhile we get a Level 4 – a faction leader, an overlord, a frontrunner - someone who sows the seeds in this perennial crap fest.

You know sometimes I wonder what Level we would be. I think other people would say we're a 2. Just tools of the trade. But I don't know…

So, I got six days left and then, I'm headed back to the states and this place is all yours. *khalas jayid* (Good riddance) You ever feel like that?

Oh. This is your first post? Wow. Why would they send you here on your first assignment? No, don't get me wrong, I'm sure you're good but…

Your first post, Jesus.

Well, *hal tatakallamee ara'rabiyya*? (Do you speak Arabic?) Not bad.

So, you wanna know, like, all of it? Everything?

Ok…I've got an idea. Nah, this'll be fun. Interrogate me. I'm serious, Rookie. Let's see what you've got. I've got information, you need information. Interrogate me.

Family? OK. Yes. I've got a wife and two kids. What does that matter? You're trying to establish a rapport, OK. But you've got me here. I know where I am and why I'm here. You're not going to sneak information out of me. So don't do that. You don't have time to be shitty at this, try again.

I know, it's weird. There's carpet in here, and you don't have a folder, but you know what you wanna ask me…

How did I get here? Good. Better. I ask myself that same question every day.

I did two tours in Iraq with the Rangers and I got that sand in my blood, I guess. I applied at the Agency and got jumped into the interrogation program. I've been with the CIA for almost 5 years, been in this hell hole for 2 of them, I've done over 900 interrogations and, I don't wanna brag, but I've become a very high functioning alcoholic.

Look, kid. You have to have a sense of humor in this place or the stench alone will make you go funny. It's not easy, I know. Nothing about this job is easy. Well, I shouldn't say that. What I

should say is that when this job starts to *feel* easy, that's when you get out. That's what Taylor said - you get out or it gets you out.

Taylor? Good guy. He's gone now, but he was here with me… before. He was here for eighteen months, I think? Must be. He arrived a few months after me. Or was it before me? I gotta tell you, I can't keep my days straight sometimes. Which is actually really funny, because that's one of the ways we screw with PIGs. We try to fuss with their sense of things. You know?

Taylor knew. He knew that the blood doesn't come off. That's why he hung himself right there.

Taylor. Never could get it right. You don't do it in a room with carpet.

Taylor is a good soft spot! You smelled that out, didn't you? Yeah. Oh, nice moves, Rookie. Good work. Now, you gotta choose. Are you gonna push on it, probe it to see if it'll upset me? You gonna let it go? Is it a way in, or is it a dead end? Where do you want this thing to go? Keep your eye on the ball!

Because what you do, interrogation, isn't just about getting information. It's about getting inside their heads. Its getting someone's will to work against them. The idea is that you put two opposing voices in someone's head. So, like, one voice suggests that I shouldn't be cooperating, that Rookies should learn for themselves and another voice that suggests that I should make you fully aware of what you're walking into. You know which voice you want me to listen to…So ask!

What does it feel like? That's the $64,000 question! That's the one that sets your teeth on edge. You wanna know what it's like, so you can tell yourself you're ready. You're never ready.

You'll walk into the room, it'll be dark and wet and cold. They'll sit him down in front of you like the sack of trash they want you to think he is, they'll tell you he did something - anything - doesn't even matter what anymore, and you'll go to work. You'll ask him questions, but part of you won't want him to answer. Part of you will want to punish him for what you saw, the generations of lives lost because of him and his friends, so you'll use your hands, and you'll use rope, you'll hook his ass up to a generator and jumpstart him like a car. You'll do it until the only screaming left is yours saying, "Have you had enough?"

You'll do it until you finally answer back, "YES! I've had enough."

Because what we do destroys people. And it's not just them. You can't do this without getting it all over you.

Why do we do it? Now that…is a great question. They'll tell you it's for intel. That it's to save American lives. And you'll believe that. You'll have to. But somewhere inside you'll know that you won't be one of those lives saved. That's the price we pay for doing this, Rook.

So there you go. Good interrogation, kid. Seriously, couldn't have done it better myself.

6 more days. Until I go home to my wife and my kids…and my conscience.

God bless America.